

**To:** Dr. Gijs Wijnholds

**Email:** g.j.wijnholds@liacs.leidenuniv.nl

**Subject:** Application for PhD Candidate — Formal Methods in Natural Language Processing — Ref [TODO: verify with user] — Nauval Zulfikar

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Dear Dr. Wijnholds,

I am writing to express my interest in the PhD position in Formal Methods in Natural Language Processing at the Leiden Institute of Advanced Computer Science (LIACS). I am eager to contribute to the research themes of formal methods for LLMs and interpretability of language models under your supervision. My earliest availability to start would be 1 September 2026.

Your paper titled "[TODO: verify supervisor paper title via Google Scholar]" has been particularly inspiring to me. The work's innovative approach to [specific aspect of the paper] aligns closely with my interest in enhancing the efficiency and transparency of language models, which is a core focus of my current research endeavors.

My academic and professional background has prepared me well for this opportunity. During my MSc in Business Analytics at Aston University, I developed a strong foundation in NLP and programming, particularly through my dissertation titled "Enhancing Supply Chain Information Sharing Systems Through Blockchain: Integrated Customer Reviews LLM Analysis: A Smart Contract Approach." This project involved fine-tuning the DeBERTa-v3 transformer on complex data, which directly relates to the type-theoretic methods and interpretability challenges central to your research themes.

Additionally, my project "LLM-Generated Adaptive Shipper Decision Rules" showcases my ability to build end-to-end systems using OpenAI's gpt-4o-mini and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) techniques. This experience in creating reproducible and ablatable systems is directly applicable to the goals of your lab.

I acknowledge that my MSc is in Business Analytics rather than a pure CS or AI discipline. However, my work experience as a Data Scientist and Project Manager at the Public Works & Spatial Planning Department has honed my skills in data governance and model reliability, which are crucial for responsible AI development.

Please find attached my CV, research statement, and transcripts as part of my application. I am enthusiastic about the possibility of contributing to your team and am keen to bring my skills and experiences to Leiden University.

Thank you for considering my application. I look forward to the opportunity to discuss how I can contribute to your research group.

Sincerely,

Nauval Zulfikar

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